

Posibilidades: What would happen if Latinos in Texas were more partisan?

Luke Bellinger lcb2896 5/5/2025 **Final Paper**

Introduction

What does the future hold for Latino politics? Whereas the answer would have been obvious in 2012—Democrats forever—recent shifts in vote choice in the Latino community have tested the perceived hold Democrats have on Latino votes (Corral and Leal 2024, 343). An interesting puzzle that arises out of Texas is how changing vote choice among Latinos will affect the composition of state legislatures. When the Texas House of Representatives map was made, it was made with certain assumptions about the distribution of the Democratic and Republican votes that are beginning to be eroded.

Democratic vote choice among Latinos is decreasing, and Republican vote choice is increasing, though a majority of Latinos remain Democrats (Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk 2025). This shift has been marked by the rise of Donald Trump and his populist, socially conservative and fiscally liberal appeals (Corral and Leal, 2024). In addition, his campaign work targeting specific sectors of Latinos, rather than going after them as a whole electorate, has netted him some gains among socially conservative Latinos, for example, Evangelicals (Corral and Leal, 2024, Ramos, 2024).

This shifting vote choice is necessarily relevant to elections in Texas. Texas Republicans, perhaps unaware that Latino areas would shift Republican, or perhaps in a bid to push aside the uncommitted and possible fleeting new Latino Republican vote, enacted a districting plan that split much of the Rio Grande Valley, El Paso, the Borderlands, San Antonio, and Latino enclaves in other cities into cracked and packed districts (Texas Legislature, 2020) in which elections are as uncompetitive as possible. Also of note is that this shifting vote choice gives Latinos less legal recourse where their districts are gerrymandered (Roberts 2023).

I test the effect that changing Latino vote choice will have on election using the current State House, , and U.S. Congressional district maps by computing county and precinct level ecological regression estimates (King 1997), for racial group support of each party and aggregate those estimates to the district level to simulate alternative elections in each State House district. Data for this analysis is taken from the Capitol Data Portal (2024).

I find that the largest effect that changing Latino vote choice can have is in the Texas House, where Republicans can gain thirteen seats from a 30-point swing. On the other hand, in the Senate and U.S. Congressional delegations, Republicans can gain three and four seats, respectively. If the Latino vote shifted 30 points in favor of Democrats, they could gain only nine House seats, one seat, and one U.S. House seat. The seats that can change parties based on Latino vote choice alone are predominantly Latino and mostly in the Borderlands and other Latino areas.

Despite all of the bluster from the media about the shifting loyalties of the Latino electorate, massive shifts in Latino vote choice are not enough to tip either chamber of the Texas Legislature in favor of Democrats, though Latino vote choice in the House may change the balance enough to make Democrat blocking of legislation easier by needing fewer Republican electors. Also, Latino vote choice can have an effect on the composition of the U.S. House, with five total seats affected by changing Latino vote choice, all in the Borderlands.

Literature

Partisanship among Latinos has been predominantly Democratic but rather ambivalent. Democratic Party identification among Latinos as of 2022 is likely between 50 and 60 percent, a decline from the 60 to 70 percent during the Obama years (Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk, 2025, figure 1). Republican identification is also rising among older generations of Latinos, whereas Independent identification is rising for younger Latinos (Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk 2025). In 2022, a majority of Latinos believed that the Democratic party represented them better than the republicans and that the Republican party did not care as much about Latinos (Pew Research Center 2022).

Several other factors also affect voter behavior; during the 2024 elections, Latino men and Latinos who attend church were more likely to vote Republican (Garcia-Rios et al. 2025). Most important issues among Latinos recently include inflation, jobs, immigration, and abortion policy; those who consider immigration and inflation to be salient were more likely to vote Republican, whereas women who consider abortion to be salient are more likely to vote Democratic (Garcia-Rios et al. 2025). These issue positions also interact with education status: “Individuals who have less than a college degree are more likely to view immigration and the border as an important political issue than those with a college degree,

therefore suggesting that those of lower socioeconomic status may view this as more of a threat. (Garcia-Rios et al. 2025, 18).” Furthermore, in the 2020 election, Biden had 8% lower Latino support than Clinton in 2016, with lower-income Latinos shifting towards Trump, as well as Catholics (Fraga, Velez, and West 2025). In 2020, the Latino percentage in a census tract was a positive predictor of Trump gains in 2016, with the average tract that is 80% Latino having a 15-point shift towards Trump between 2016 and 2020 (Fraga, Velez, and West 2025).

The Trump effect on the Latino vote is unique, as even his 2016 bid outperformed Romney’s 2012 campaign among low-income Latinos. Counterintuitively enough, the shift towards Republicans among Latinos is seen most among poorer Latinos and those who live in overwhelmingly Latino areas, which do not make up a traditional base of any conservative American party in history. Even his dogwhistling or just whistling (‘they’re sending rapists’ etc.) was not nearly as poorly received by Latinos as Democrats may have hoped: “Trump received a somewhat lower Latino vote share than did Romney, the degree of this underperformance was surprisingly modest in light of his campaign rhetoric, [and] Democratic Party efforts to highlight this rhetoric, and media coverage that accentuated the divide between Latinos and Trump. (Corral and Leal 2020, 1128).”

Latinos, however, are not Liberals or Progressive *per se*, they fit well into a populist camp, favoring bigger government rather than smaller, while also holding on to conservative social values (Corral and Leal, 2024, 343). As such, it is not entirely surprising that Latinos have shifted in favor of Trump, just as they did Bush some time ago (Corral and Leal, 2024, 342). This is what has struck me about the political leaning of Latinos for as long as I’ve been doing race and ethnic politics;¹ Latinos may be socially progressive or socially conservative, but almost all are fiscally liberal, broadly in favor of spending on things like Medicare, Social Security, etc. (Corral and Leal, 2024, 344). Thus even the most historically conservative Latinos, Miami Cubans, remain in favor of the Affordable Care Act (Corral and Leal 2024, 344), otherwise loathed by other Republicans.

Part of this shift towards the Republicans also comes from Evangelicalism rising in the Latino electorate. Evangelical Latinos are far more likely to be conservative, Republican, anti-same sex marriage and pro-Israel than other religious groups (Gibson and Hare, 2012).

¹ Not very long, mind you

Evangelicals of all stripes fit well within the Trump movement, as their belief that God is coming to America soon and that American society is being corrupted by progressive social values, including the increasing acceptance of homosexuality and abortion (Ramos 2024). Much of Ramos' ethnographic work took place in South Texas, one of the areas that this paper studies. Trump's targeting of Latino communities through Evangelical movements (and Democrats' lack of similar messaging) are part of his recent successes in the Latino electorate (Corral and Leal 2024, 347-348). Latinos, are not, however, as homogeneous as anybody makes them out to be. What, then will happen to elections as this vote choice shifts?

In Texas, both Democrats and Republicans gerrymander to make elections as uncompetitive as possible.² The current House districts map, plan H2316, includes many unusual districts, such as District 55 in Killeen, which is an enclave of District 54, District 21 near Beaumont (Dade Phelan's district) which is not contiguous at high tide, and District 33 in the Dallas area, which is made up of two halves separated by a lake (Texas Legislature 2020). These nonsensical salamanders have the effect of making most elections in Texas uncompetitive³ (Capitol Data Portal, 2024). As race and partisanship are highly correlated in Texas, partisan gerrymandering leads to gerrymandering in minority communities, a practice that is currently undergoing litigation (Fair Maps, 2021). Voting Rights Act precedent set in the case of *Thornburg v. Gingles* and reaffirmed in *Allen v. Milligan* requires the drawing of majority-minority-group districts if:

1. The 'minority group must be sufficiently large and [geographically] (original emphasis) compact to constitute a majority in a reasonably configured district.'"
2. "Second, the minority group must be able to show that it is politically cohesive."
3. "The minority must be able to demonstrate that the white majority votes sufficiently as a bloc to enable it . . . to defeat the minority's preferred candidate." (Roberts 2023, 3)

Thus, voting as a unified bloc is mandatory to prevent gerrymandering of a minority group. Given that the Latino vote has shifted, especially in Texas, it is unclear whether there would be legal redress for gerrymandering in Latino communities. Thus, evaluating how Latino communities in Texas are affected by gerrymandering is an important avenue of

² I asked Tom Oliverson about redistricting during his bid for speaker. He said that the redistricting committee agreed on creating as many "safe" seats as possible.

³ Many elections in the 2022 House cycle were canceled because only one candidate was running.

research that can shine light on the extent to which Latino communities can wield electoral power under the current gerrymandered map.

Theory

Republican vote choice is rising in the Latino community, to an extent we have not seen since the 2004 elections (Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk, 2025). On the other hand, it is not clear yet whether this shift will hold, or if it is based solely on support for Donald Trump, similar to those same 2004 elections (Corral and Leal 2024). Because Latinos are still predominantly Democratic, Republican lawmakers have already drawn lines that are meant to crack Latino communities wherever possible (See Appendix Maps 1, 2, and 3). Rather than seeing Latinos as possible partners in an even larger Texas Republican party, state Republican lawmakers are left with the map made several years ago, which does not take into account the shifting political loyalties of Latinos. Therefore, we are left with an open question as to how the assumptions of the map made in 2021 as to partisan population distribution hold up today in a more uncertain political climate. Republican lawmakers are tasked with trying to figure out not where Democrats and Republicans are, but rather where they will be in several years. Because of this, Latino political representation at present works from the assumption that Latinos are in the minority. Despite Latinos making up a plurality of Texas's population, Latino political representation is diminished by the gerrymandered map (See Appendix Note 1).

I think that it's possible that Republicans' expectations about their future ruling coalition may have been slightly wrong. I say that because, as the map is currently configured, Democrats have strong majorities in packed districts along the Rio Grande Valley and in major cities. Because these districts are so heavily Democratic, they can't really be exploited for Republican gain as Latinos shift Republican during the 2024 election cycle. The point may be moot, however, as Republicans are already the majority in both houses. Given that they favor non-competitive elections to competitive ones, the benefit of gaining more seats by drawing possible Republican Hispanic districts could be outweighed by the prospect of losing those districts. A clear majority of Latinos are still Democratic (Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk, 2025, figure 1), and almost all support spending programs like Obamacare, which even Texas Republicans would be skeptical of (Corral and Leal, 2024, 344). In the long term,

these changes in vote choice may affect how Texas Republicans gerrymander maps in the future.

Research Expectations

Given how gerrymandered the map of Texas already is, I am skeptical of the extent to which Latinos could flip electoral districts, given that in many places elections are uncontested, and in most others the majority party in the district has an insurmountable lead over the minority party. As such, I expect changes in Latino Democratic vote choice to have little to no effect on the overall composition of the Texas House, Senate, or Congressional Delegation:

H₁: Increasing or decreasing the Latino Democratic vote choice will not have a large effect on the number of Democrats elected to the Texas House, Senate, or Congressional Delegation.

On the other hand, Latinos form a clear majority in many counties in Texas, and are geographically compact enough to require packed districts in San Antonio, the Rio Grande Valley, and El Paso (Texas Legislature 2020). It is possible that Latino vote in cracked districts may overcome the heavy bias towards Republican candidates.

H₂: Any effects on elections will come from predominantly Hispanic cracked districts.

Data

The main source of data that this analysis uses is Voter Tabulation District (VTD) counts for elections in 2022 and 2024. (Capitol Data Portal, 2024). These are taken from the Capitol Data Portal and are merged together to get precinct-level results for every State House, State Senate, and U.S. Congressional election and for the U.S. Senate and Gubernatorial elections. Because many State House seats are uncontested or not contested by both Democrats and Republicans, the vote counts of any 2024 election that did not include a candidate from both parties is replaced by the precinct votes for U.S. Senator in the election between Cruz and Allred, and uncontested elections in 2022 are substituted with the Gubernatorial election between Abbott and O'Rourke. I chose these alternatives because they seemed to be better substitutes than other options, such as the Presidential election, which included the unusual candidate of Donald Trump, and lesser-known statewide elections, such as railroad commissioner. Demographic data for each VTD is also taken from the Capitol

Data Portal and was originally measured by the 2020 Census. The demographics assigned to each VTD include voting age population and voting age population of Whites, Blacks, Latinos, and Asians. There are several limitations in the data. The vap and total number of Democratic or Republican votes cast are different, which may lead to measurement bias or error in any model, as the proportions of each race's VAP in a district do not necessarily represent the proportion of each race's votes in the election. Additionally, there are several hundred observations of precincts in sparsely populated areas that had no votes cast at all. For visualizations, a shapefile of Texas VTDs is also taken from the Capitol Data Portal.

Design

Ecological inference (EI) is a method proposed to forecast racial votes at the precinct level (King 1997). Ecological inference is based on the idea that there are four ratios of interest in a precinct: two groups of voters and votes for two candidates. Ecological inference finds coefficients for each group ratio to apply to each candidate ratio. To test H_1 , ecological inference is used to predict Democratic and Republican vote shares from each racial group. The eiCompare package in R is used to run iterative ecological regressions on each racial group and precinct (Barreto et al. 2020). The iterative nature means that 2 by 2 ecological inferences are run with dependent variable terms for Democratic and Republican vote share and independent variable terms for a race as a percentage of the precinct population and the percentage of the remainder of the population. Essentially, every combination of party and race are tested for most precincts across Texas. Though there are more complex EI models for measuring multiple racial groups and candidates, they do not perform significantly better than iterative EI (Barreto et al. 2022).

To prevent spurious results and to optimize processing, counties with fewer than 5 precincts are evaluated as a whole county rather than as individual precincts. The resulting coefficients from each observation (precinct or small county) for each race-party pair are multiplied by the VAP of each race to get predicted election results for each district. These coefficients are manipulated to project vote totals at different levels of Democratic or Republican party support. Specifically, I am testing 10, 20, and 30 point swings in Latino Democratic and Republican identification across all precincts, where a 10 point swing is Latinos favoring Democrats by 5% more and Republicans by 5% less. These vote totals are then aggregated by district to forecast the outcome of an election. One major flaw, as noted

before, is that this analysis does not include turnout. (See Appendix Note 2) It also assumes that populations for each race remain stable and that there is no movement of Republican voters from precinct to precinct. These limitations are borne out of the data and my lack of methodological sophistication.

Results

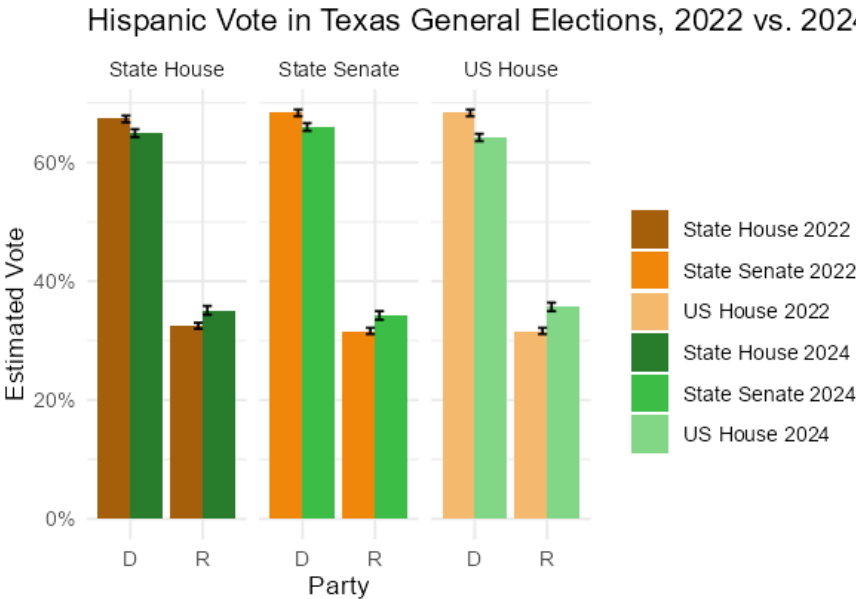


Table 1. Projected Seats for Changes in Latino Vote Choice

Map	Party	R+30	R+20	R+10	EI at 0	Truth	D+10	D+20	D+30	Gain
House	Republican	101	97	91	88	88	84	81	79	13
House	Democrat	49	53	59	62	62	66	69	71	9
Senate	Republican	24	21	21	19	20	19	19	19	4
Senate	Democrat	7	10	10	12	11	12	12	12	1
U.S. Congress	Republican	28	27	26	25	25	24	24	24	3
U.S. Congress	Democrat	10	11	12	13	13	14	14	14	1

First off, there was a shift between 2022 and 2024 for Latino voters in Texas, though only by a couple points. This shift is not nearly as important as some commentators would make it out to be (Sandoval 2025, Ramos 2024). It seems that the narrative around Latinos shifting more Republican in this election cycle is not nearly significant enough to warrant

writing books about or having a cable news show discussion on. The difference, even for the highest 95% confidence interval in 2022 and lowest in 2024, is only four percent. This difference is also somewhat affected by dropoff. State House districts saw a very small shift towards Republicans, whereas Congressional districts saw a larger shift towards Republicans. This may have something to do with individuals supporting Trump at the top of the ballot but not continuing to vote Republican in progressively lower races. However, all of these effects, while significant, are within a couple points. It seems that there was no massive shift to Republicans from Latinos in this election, at least in Texas.

To start analyzing Table 1, the ecological inference estimates at 0% swing were perfect for the House and Congressional maps and only one off for the Senate map. This is remarkable, as the only predictor used in the model was race. Race, alone, can predict Texas elections almost perfectly. This has some broader legal implications as to whether racially polarized voting occurs, as per the previously mentioned Gingles test.

Starting with the State House, Democrats could gain nine seats from a swing of 30% (again, defined as an increase in Democratic vote of 15% and a decrease in Republican vote of 15% in all precincts). This is not enough to flip the House, but it makes the passing of legislation more precarious. Take, for instance, school vouchers. On the first pass, 21 Republicans in the House voted against Abbott's legislation (Svitek, 2024), whereas on the second pass, only two voted against (Astudillo, 2025). At present, for Republican legislation to be blocked, some 13 or 14 Republicans would need to vote against it, whereas if Democrats began massively winning Latinos, only 4 or 5 Republicans would be necessary to block legislation. On the other hand, if Republicans had a 30-point swing, they would control 101 seats, with 13 of these being the newly Latino Republican districts. Though having 13 Republicans would give Latinos some sway in the legislature, it is unlikely they, alone, could change Republican policies through their influence, as there would remain many Republican districts not affected by a change in Latino vote choice.

In the Senate and Congressional Delegation, however, there would be far less change. Even if Democrats massively began winning the Latino vote, they could only stand to gain 1 Senate seat and one U.S. House seat. These maps are more durable to change in the political landscape because they have fewer districts; therefore, "more" gerrymandering can be had to create safer districts, given that meeting the geographical and population constraints is less

difficult to achieve. Republicans, however, stand to gain more than Democrats if they were to begin winning more of the Latino vote. Even a 10% swing in the Latino vote could cause the Republicans to pick up one more U.S. House district, and massively converting Latinos would net them 3 new Congresspeople. From a national perspective, given the knife-edge majority that Republicans currently hold in the U.S. House of Representatives (“United...”, 2025), picking up even a couple more districts in Latino areas of Texas could tip the balance of the U.S. House in Republicans’ favor in a hotly contested upcoming midterm. I find Hypothesis 1 to be broadly correct, in that Latinos alone cannot flip the House or Senate, though changes in Latino vote choice could make it easier for Democrats to oppose legislation in the House by needing fewer Republican defectors.

For Hypothesis 2, I refer to the maps in the Appendix. As can be seen, most of the districts that can be affected by changes in Latino vote choice are in the borderlands, a predominantly Latino region. While it seems that Latinos alone do not have the ability to make massive changes in the composition of the Texas government, they certainly can make races for individual candidates in the borderlands more competitive than the gerrymandered map was meant to allow for. In addition, given that four U.S. House seats could change hands, borderlands Latinos can have an effect on politics beyond Texas. Though perhaps tautological, the districts most affected by Latino vote choice are in predominantly Latino regions of Texas.

Conclusion

Whereas changing political identification may be momentarily interesting to political commentators, it seems as if the Republican majority in the House and Senate is durable to change in either direction. The heavily gerrymandered maps make it such that even gigantic swings in political identification have little impact on the composition of the Texas Government. This is an interesting finding because even though this Latino shift towards Republicans is talked about on the news and frequently written about in political science circles (Corral and Leal, 2024, Garcia-Rios et al, 2025, Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk, 2025), it does not seem to have a very large impact on state politics. Texas’s maps are gerrymandered to prevent surprises from happening, and it seems that even though 2020 Republican lawmakers may not have been able to predict a Latino shift towards Republicans, the maps are durable.

However, individuals voting for candidates in predominantly Latino areas may be more likely to see changes in individual seats. Even though the overall agency of Latinos may be diminished by a lack of ability to change government, it seems that the only places where competition could return to the Texas political scene are precisely in the heavily Latino areas that are cracked to prevent competition.

Given previous literature, it is unclear whether the small Latino shift to Republicans is significant enough to grow by the next districting cycle, or whether Trump's momentary popularity and populism may fade away to a more popular Democratic candidate, as Bush's popularity faded for Obama's. If it were to do so, it would be interesting to see if Republicans try to gain more votes by using increasing Republicanism in the Rio Grande Valley to their advantage, or whether they would continue their strategy of making elections uncompetitive in every possible place. This shift does, however, change the arithmetic of how districting will be done going into 2030 (or earlier should the current map be declared unlawful).

To conclude, this article contributes several observations as to Latino political representation in a gerrymandered system. Latinos, if they were to change their vote choice in favor of Republicans, could net Republicans a giant majority in the Texas House and a larger majority in the Texas Senate, though these new seats would not come with any type of blackmail position, as Republicans already held majorities in both houses. If they voted very heavily Democrat, they would not be able to change the composition of either chamber, though they could be put in a better position to oppose Republican legislation in the House. Finally, given that the districts affected by Latino vote choice are those predominantly Latino districts in the Borderlands, Latino agency can be effectively used in supporting or opposing individual candidates in those districts, which will have the greatest substantive effect on U.S. House elections, where five possible "swing" districts could tip the balance in favor of a particular party.

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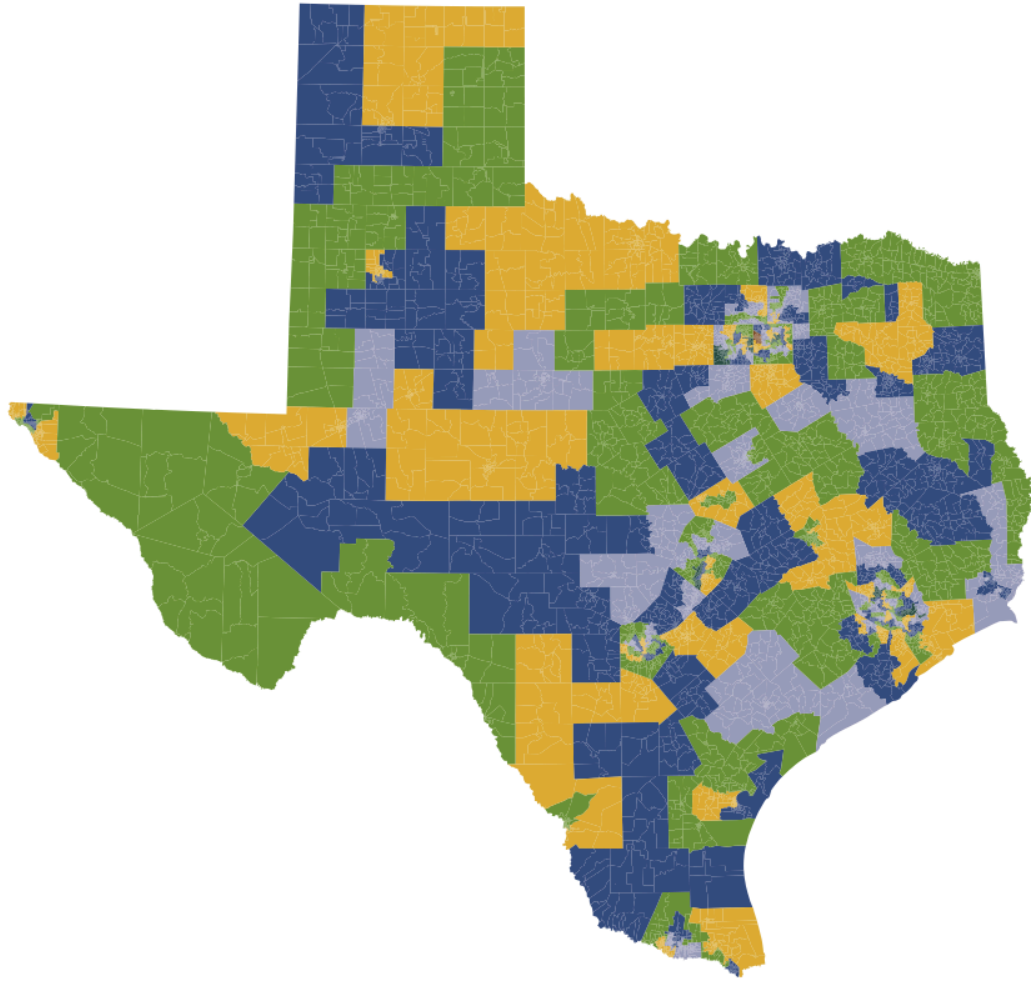
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Appendix

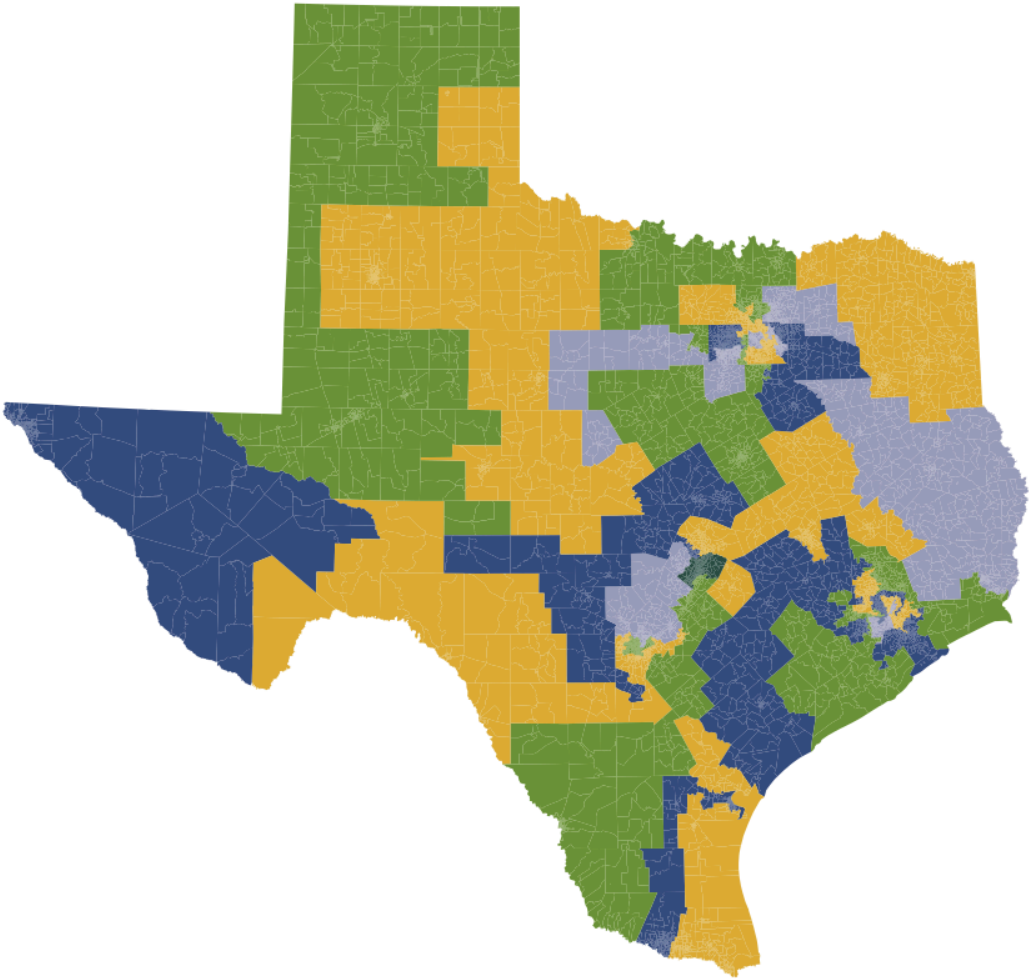
Appendix Note 1: Latinos make up a plurality of the Texas population (39.8%), presently more than Whites (39.6%) as of 2020 according to the same redistricting data (Capitol Data Portal, 2024). For districts that have a Latino majority, there are 41 House Districts (27.3%), 8 Senate Districts (25.8%) and 10 Congressional Districts (26.3%). To be fair, proportionality is not required by the VRA and it is possible that this deficiency in representation is caused by unequal population distribution, but I think the point stands that Republicans have tried to gerrymander the Borderlands, as can be seen in maps 1, 2, and 3.

Appendix Note 2: I have explained this problem to Dr. Shaw, but I am not sure if I got my point across exactly, so I will explain further. Because the “simulated elections” are simply a function of $\text{White VAP} \times \text{White Democrat Estimate} + \text{Hispanic VAP} \times \text{Hispanic Democrat Estimate} \dots$ for all races and candidates, this assumes that the demographic breakdown of the final vote is the same as the demographics of the district at-large. The problem is that Whites vote at a higher rate than Hispanics, so this aggregation of votes may underestimate the number of White voters in the final vote tally compared to Hispanics. I don’t think this is a problem because the EI model still predicted the current distribution of seats in all maps almost perfectly.

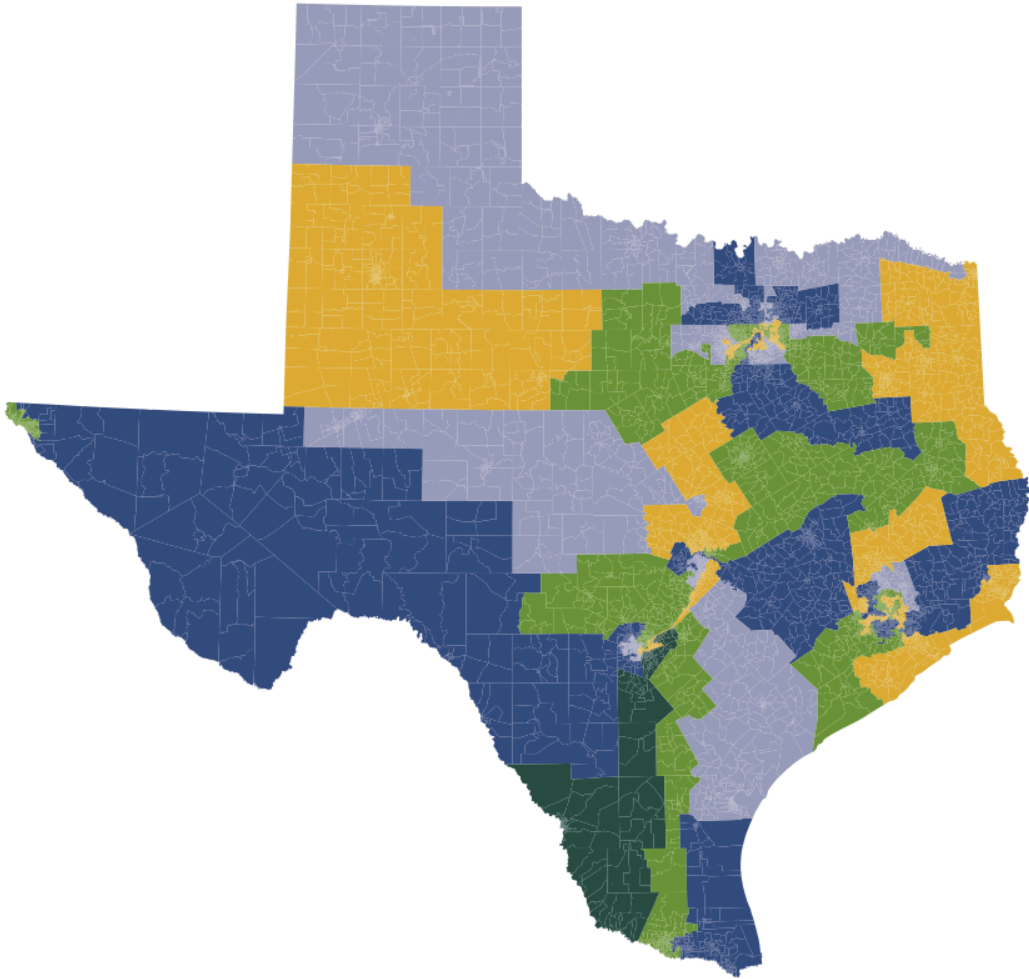
Map 1: Current State House Districts



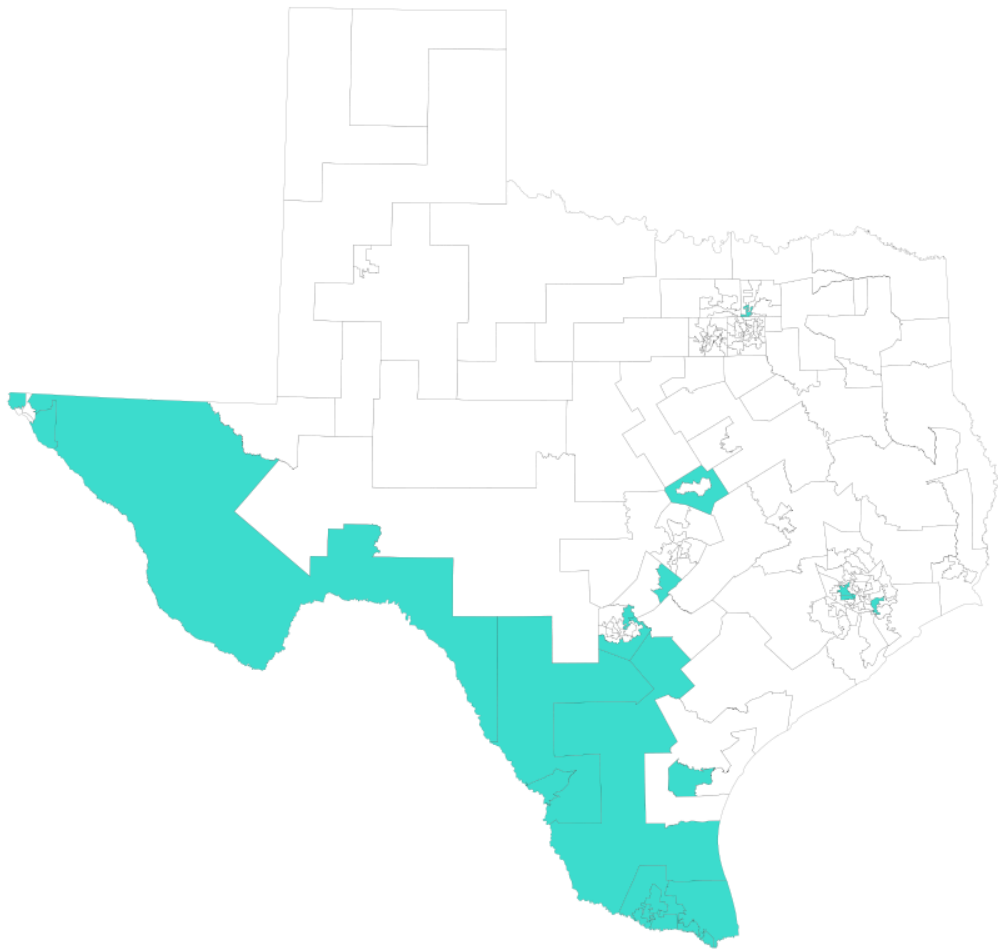
Map 2: Current State Senate Districts



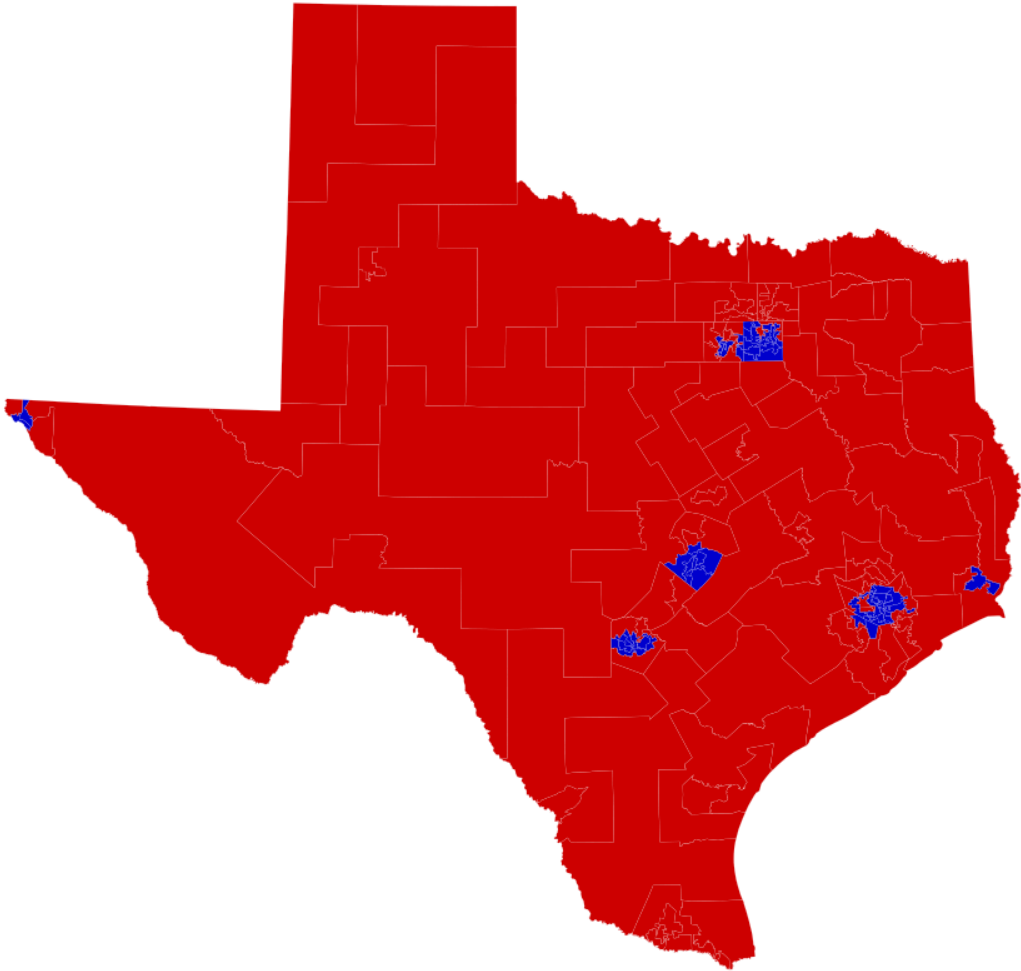
Map 3: Current Congressional Districts



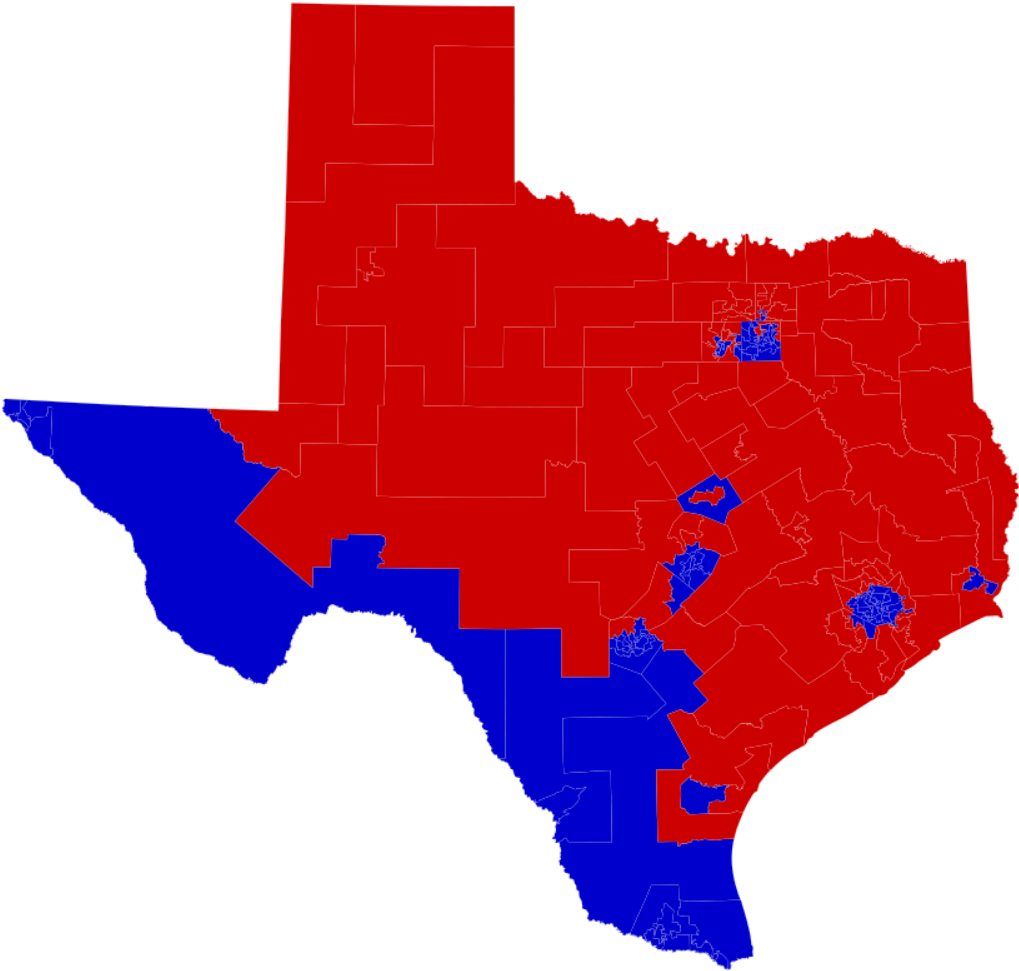
Map 4: House Districts That Can Be Affected
by Latino Vote Swing



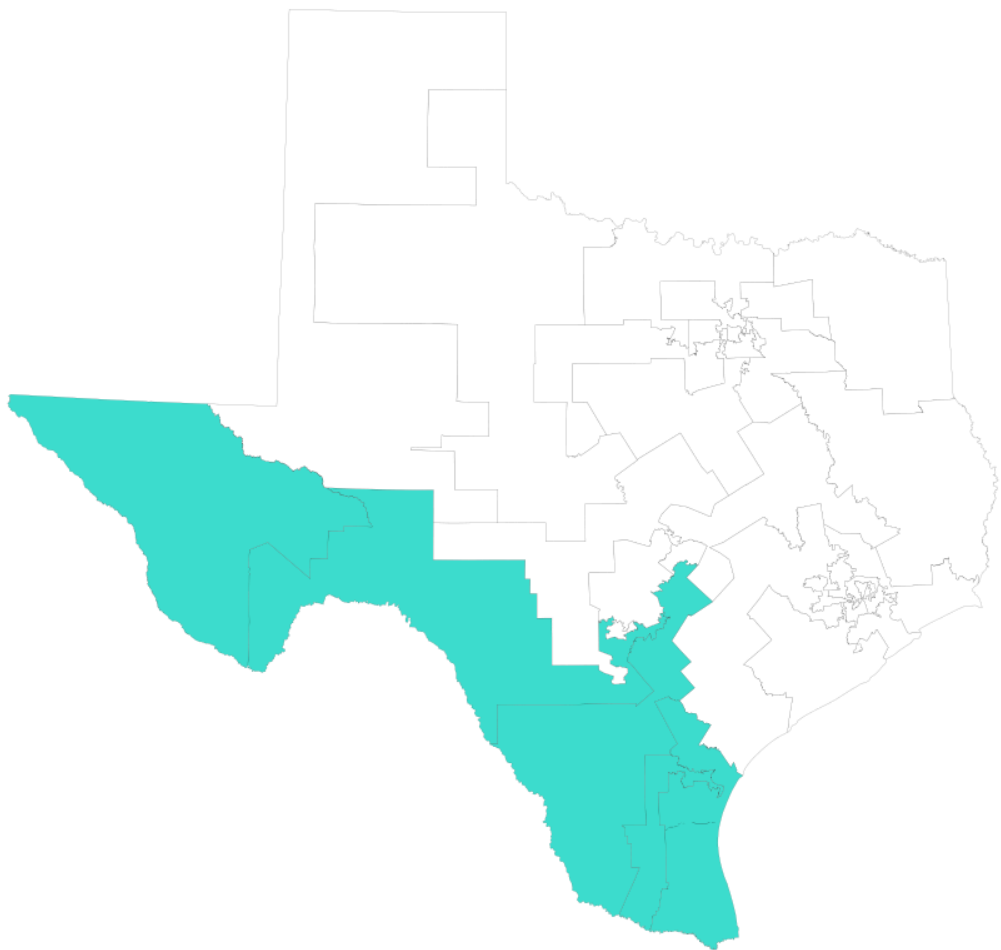
Map 5: House Districts at R+30



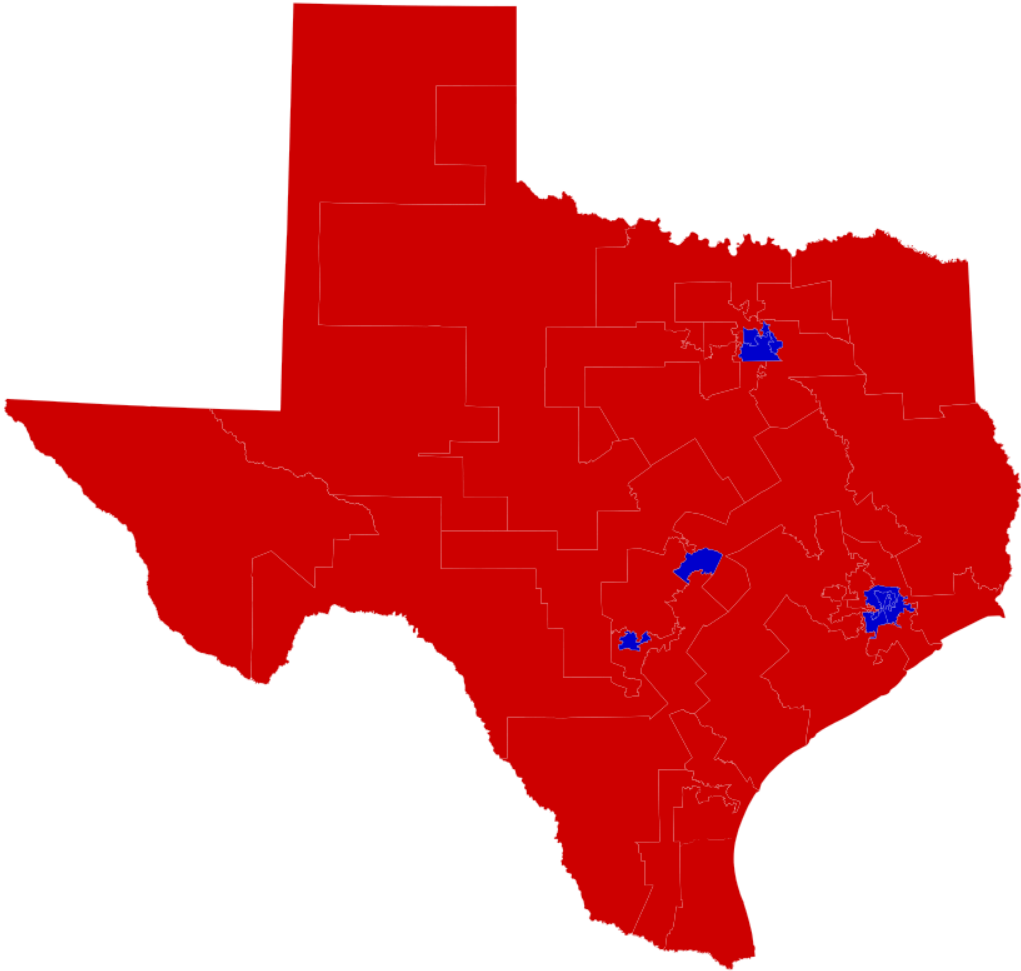
Map 6: House Districts at D+30



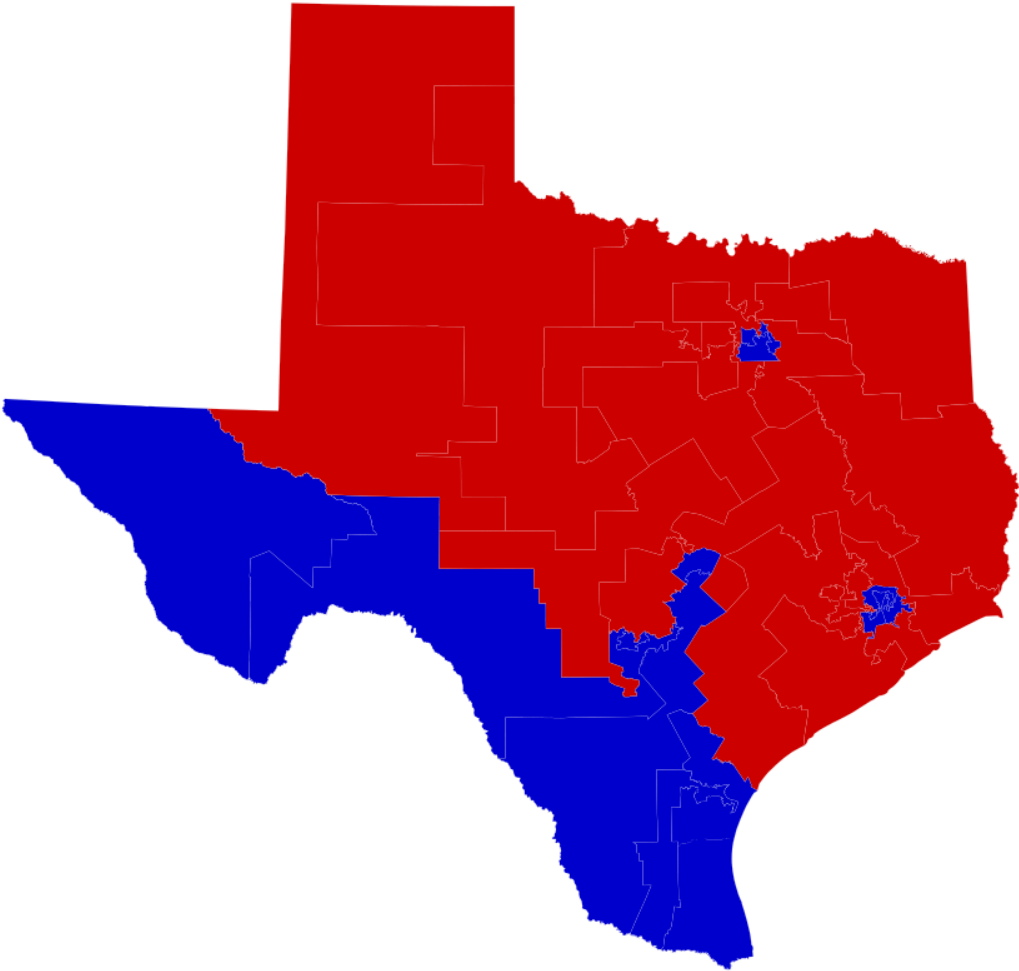
Map 7: Senate Districts That Can Be Affected
by Latino Vote Swing



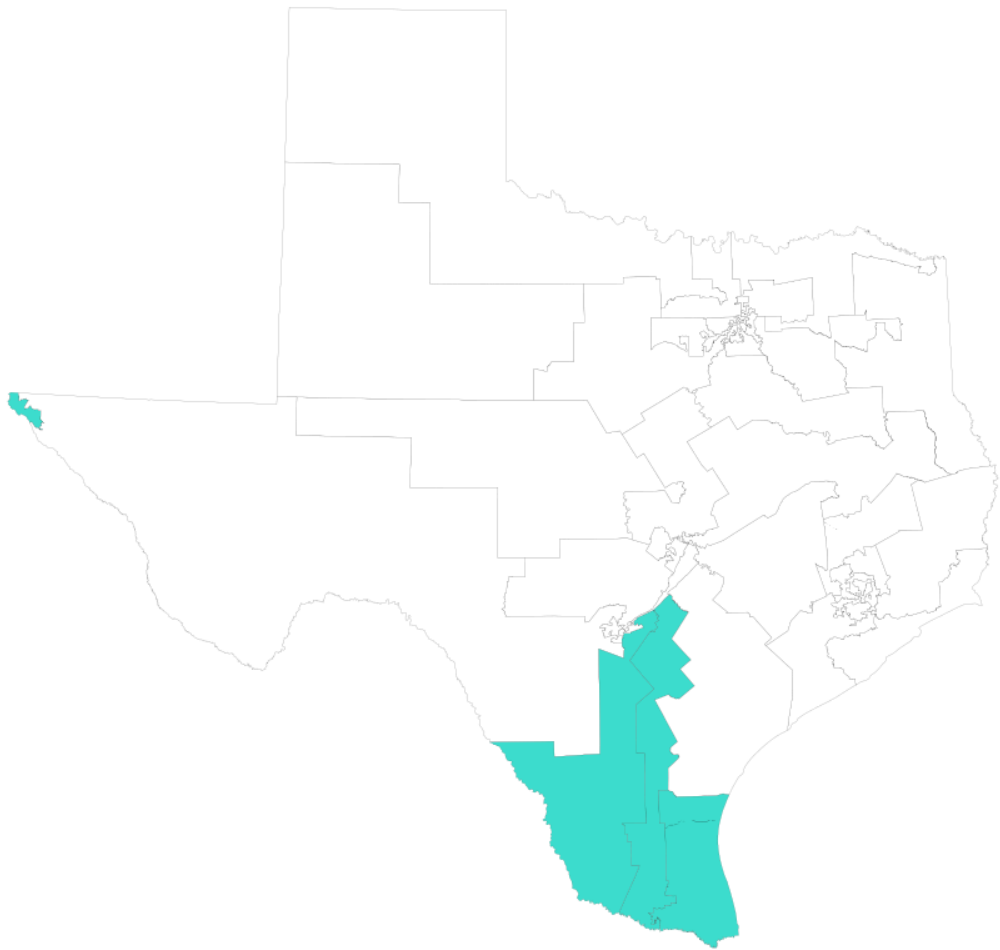
Map 8: Senate Districts at R+30



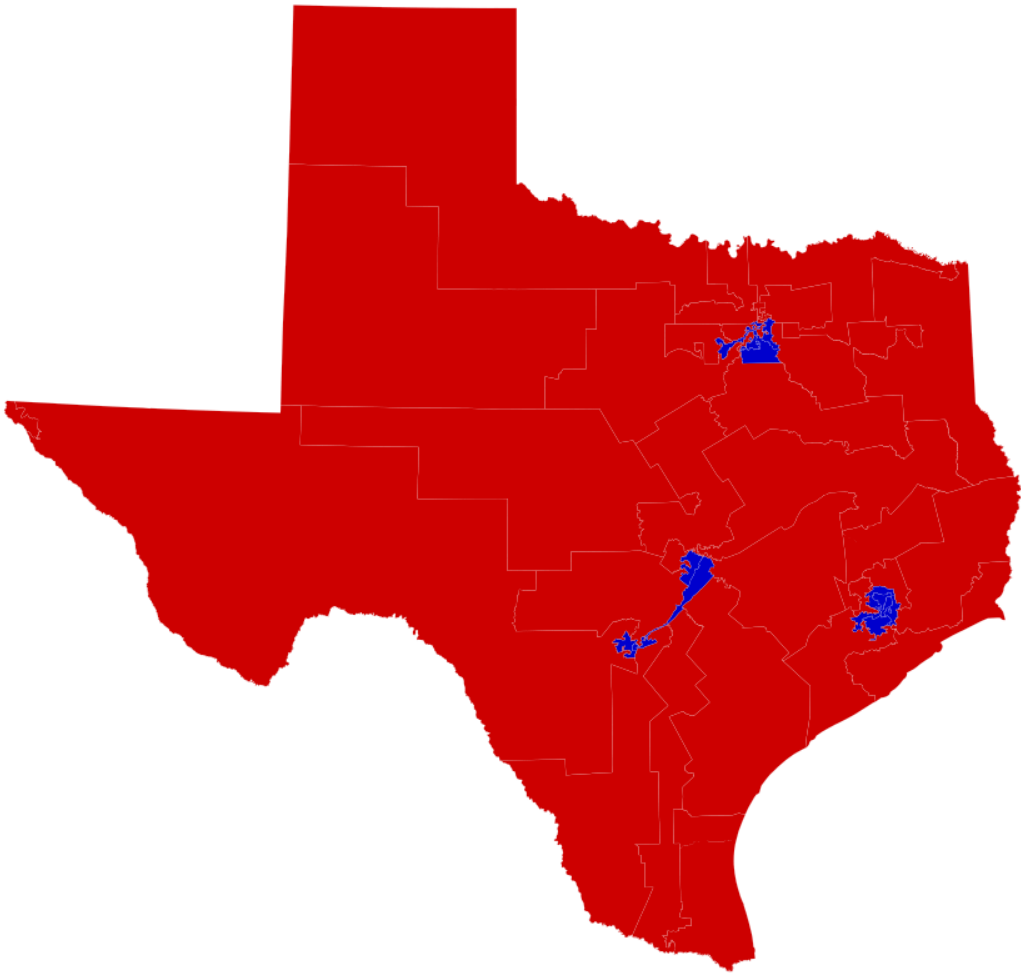
Map 9: Senate Districts at D+30



Map 10: Congressional Districts That Can Be Affected
by Latino Vote Swing



Map 11: Congressional Districts at R+30



Map 12: Congressional Districts at D+30

